

# Human Resources Management

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**Course:** CS — Certified Secretaries

**Level:** Foundation Level (CS15)

**Last updated:** 29 July 2026

**Syllabus version:** Based on the standard KASNEB CS Foundation Level Human Resources Management syllabus topics (CS15) — HR planning, recruitment and selection, training and development, and performance management. Authored from general human-resources knowledge and standard syllabus topic coverage, not copied from any existing notes provider or study guide. Cross-check terminology and emphasis against the current KASNEB syllabus and examiner's reports before the exam.

**Original work notice.** Every explanation, worked example, and question in this document was written from scratch for this paper. No text has been copied or paraphrased from any KASNEB past paper, textbook, or third-party notes/study guide. The scenarios and practice questions are original.

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## 1. What is human resources management?

**Human resources management (HRM)** is the function responsible for managing an organisation's workforce effectively — attracting, developing, motivating and retaining the people needed to achieve organisational objectives, while ensuring fair, legally compliant treatment of employees throughout their employment.

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## 2. Human resource planning

**HR planning** forecasts an organisation's future staffing needs (numbers, skills) and develops plans to meet them — through recruitment, training, or restructuring — ensuring the organisation has the right people, with the right skills, at the right time, rather than reacting to staffing gaps only after they become urgent problems.

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## 3. Recruitment and selection

**Recruitment** is the process of attracting a pool of suitable candidates for a vacancy (e.g. through advertising, referrals, recruitment agencies). **Selection** is the process of choosing the most suitable candidate from that pool, typically using tools such as application review, interviews, and (for some roles) tests or assessment centres. A well-run selection process is structured and consistent across candidates, reducing the risk of bias and improving the likelihood of a genuinely suitable hire.

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## 4. Induction and orientation

**Induction (orientation)** introduces a new employee to the organisation — its culture, policies, their specific role and team, and practical matters (systems access, workplace procedures). Effective induction reduces the time a new employee takes to become fully productive, and reduces early staff turnover caused by unclear expectations or a poor first impression of the organisation.

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## 5. Training and development

**Training** builds specific skills/knowledge needed for an employee's current role; **development** builds broader capability for future roles/responsibilities. Common training methods: on-the-job training (learning while performing actual work, often with supervision/mentoring) and off-the-job training (structured courses/workshops away from the

immediate work environment). Effective training should be tied to a genuine, identified skills gap, not delivered generically without reference to actual organisational needs.

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## 6. Performance management and appraisal

**Performance management** is the ongoing process of setting clear expectations, monitoring performance, and providing feedback to help employees meet organisational objectives. A **performance appraisal** is a periodic, structured review of an employee's performance against agreed objectives, typically informing decisions on development needs, promotion, or (where necessary) performance improvement measures. Effective appraisal requires objective, specific criteria known in advance — vague or inconsistently applied criteria undermine both fairness and the appraisal's usefulness for genuine development planning.

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## 7. Employee relations and discipline, basics

**Employee relations** covers the overall relationship between an organisation and its employees, including how grievances and disciplinary matters are handled. A fair **disciplinary process** typically requires: informing the employee clearly of the alleged issue, giving them a genuine opportunity to respond, and applying a proportionate, consistent outcome — natural justice principles that protect both the organisation (from unfair-dismissal claims) and the employee (from arbitrary treatment).

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## 8. Human resources and the company secretarial function

A company secretary often has direct HR-adjacent responsibilities: ensuring board-level HR policies (e.g. executive remuneration, succession planning) are properly documented and approved through correct governance procedure, and supporting the remuneration committee (where one exists) in setting and disclosing senior executive pay. Understanding HR fundamentals helps a company secretary engage meaningfully with these governance-level HR matters, even without direct operational HR responsibility for the wider workforce.

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## 9. Full worked question — evaluating a recruitment process weakness

**Scenario.** A company fills a management vacancy by directly appointing a manager's personal acquaintance, without advertising the role or interviewing any other candidates.

**Required:** (a) Identify the weakness in this recruitment approach. (b) Explain the risk this creates. (c) Recommend an improvement.

**Solution:**

(a) The weakness is a **lack of a structured, open recruitment and selection process** — the role was filled through a personal connection rather than a fair competitive process open to suitably qualified candidates.

(b) This creates a risk of hiring a less suitable candidate than might otherwise have been available, exposes the organisation to perceptions (or actual instances) of favouritism/nepotism, and can undermine staff morale and trust in the fairness of the organisation's processes generally.

(c) **Recommendation:** advertise the vacancy appropriately, define clear selection criteria in advance, and assess all candidates (including any personal acquaintances of existing staff) through the same structured, documented process to ensure the most suitable candidate is genuinely selected and the process is defensible if later questioned.

## 10. Practice examination — KASNEB-style paper (original, not a past paper)

**Note on format.** This section is laid out the way a KASNEB CS examination paper is laid out — a timed paper with five compulsory 20-mark questions — purely so you can practise under realistic exam conditions. Every question below is an original scenario written for this document. **It is not a reproduction of any actual KASNEB past examination paper.**

### CS FOUNDATION LEVEL — HUMAN RESOURCES MANAGEMENT (PRACTICE PAPER)

**TIME ALLOWED: 3 HOURS**

*Instructions to candidates: Answer ALL FIVE questions. Each question carries 20 marks. Show all workings clearly.*

#### QUESTION ONE

(a) Define "human resources management" and its core purpose. (8 marks)

(b) Explain the purpose of human resource planning. (6 marks)

(c) Distinguish between recruitment and selection. (6 marks)

(Total: 20 marks)

**QUESTION TWO**

(a) Explain the purpose of induction/orientation for a new employee. *(8 marks)*

(b) Distinguish between training and development. *(6 marks)*

(c) Distinguish between on-the-job and off-the-job training. *(6 marks)*

*(Total: 20 marks)*

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**QUESTION THREE**

(a) Define "performance appraisal" and explain its purpose. *(8 marks)*

(b) Explain why objective, specific criteria (known in advance) matter for effective appraisal. *(6 marks)*

(c) Outline the elements of a fair disciplinary process. *(6 marks)*

*(Total: 20 marks)*

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**QUESTION FOUR**

A company fills a finance officer vacancy by directly appointing a director's relative, without advertising the role or considering other candidates.

(a) Identify the weakness in this process. *(6 marks)*

(b) Explain the risks this creates for the organisation. *(8 marks)*

(c) Recommend how the company should have handled the vacancy. *(6 marks)*

*(Total: 20 marks)*

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**QUESTION FIVE**

(a) Explain the company secretary's involvement in HR-related governance matters. *(12 marks)*

(b) Explain why understanding HR fundamentals is useful to a company secretary, even without direct operational HR responsibility. *(8 marks)*

*(Total: 20 marks)*

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**11. Marking guide — model answers to the practice examination****QUESTION ONE**

- (a) (8 marks) — HRM manages an organisation's workforce effectively — attracting, developing, motivating and retaining staff to achieve objectives, while ensuring fair, compliant treatment.
- (b) (6 marks) — HR planning forecasts future staffing needs and develops plans to meet them, ensuring the right people/skills are available when needed.
- (c) (6 marks) — Recruitment attracts a pool of suitable candidates; selection chooses the most suitable candidate from that pool.

## **QUESTION TWO**

- (a) (8 marks) — Induction introduces a new employee to the organisation's culture, policies, role and practical matters, reducing time to productivity and early turnover.
- (b) (6 marks) — Training builds skills for the current role; development builds broader capability for future roles/responsibilities.
- (c) (6 marks) — On-the-job: learning while performing actual work, often supervised. Off-the-job: structured courses/workshops away from the immediate work environment.

## **QUESTION THREE**

- (a) (8 marks) — A performance appraisal is a periodic, structured review of performance against agreed objectives; purpose: informing development, promotion, or performance-improvement decisions.
- (b) (6 marks) — Objective, known-in-advance criteria ensure fairness and consistency, and make the appraisal genuinely useful for development planning rather than feeling arbitrary.
- (c) (6 marks) — Clearly inform the employee of the alleged issue; give a genuine opportunity to respond; apply a proportionate, consistent outcome.

## **QUESTION FOUR**

- (a) (6 marks) — Lack of a structured, open recruitment/selection process — the role was filled via personal connection without competition.
- (b) (8 marks) — Risk of hiring a less suitable candidate than otherwise available; perceptions/instances of favouritism/nepotism; undermined staff morale and trust in process fairness.
- (c) (6 marks) — Advertise the vacancy, define clear selection criteria in advance, assess all candidates (including personal acquaintances) through the same structured, documented process.

## **QUESTION FIVE**

- (a) (12 marks) — Ensuring board-level HR policies (e.g. executive remuneration, succession planning) are properly documented and approved through correct governance procedure;

supporting the remuneration committee in setting/disclosing senior executive pay.

(b) (8 marks) — It allows meaningful engagement with governance-level HR matters that regularly reach the board (remuneration, succession, disciplinary matters involving senior staff), even without day-to-day operational HR responsibility for the wider workforce.

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## 12. Exam technique and revision checklist

- Always distinguish related HR term pairs precisely: recruitment vs selection, training vs development, on-the-job vs off-the-job — these are frequently and specifically tested.
- Scenario questions (recruitment/discipline weaknesses): identify the specific weakness, then the risk, then a specific recommendation — a three-part structure examiners commonly expect.
- Appraisal/discipline questions: always mention fairness and consistency explicitly — a recurring theme across HR topics.
- CS-specific angle: always connect HR topics back to the company secretary's governance-support role (board HR policy documentation, remuneration committee support) when a question asks about the CS's involvement specifically.
- Don't answer HR questions purely generically — tie answers to the specific organisational risk or governance angle the question raises.

### Quick revision — one line per topic:

1. HRM: managing workforce to achieve objectives, fairly and compliantly.
  2. HR planning: forecasting future staffing needs and planning to meet them.
  3. Recruitment (attracting candidates) vs selection (choosing the best one).
  4. Induction: introduces new employee to org/role, reduces time-to-productivity and early turnover.
  5. Training (current-role skills) vs development (future-role capability).
  6. Performance appraisal: structured periodic review against agreed objectives.
  7. Fair discipline: inform of issue, allow response, proportionate/consistent outcome.
  8. Company secretary's HR role: governance-level (remuneration, succession), not operational HR.
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*End of study notes. This document is intended as original exam-preparation material and should be used alongside the current official KASNEB syllabus and examiner's reports for the paper.*